RUB | SOMMERSEMESTER 2026

Grammar BM

Last-Minute Guide

Central exam
Friday, 24 July 2026 | 14:00-16:00 | 90 minutes | 100 points

Source priority
Official SoSe 2026 Theory Reader -> Moodle mock feedback -> new-format exercises -> old exams for extra practice.

Online trainer
https://sirmrba.github.io/grammar-sprint-sidelya/

Prepared as a focused exam aid for Sidelya. The examples are original practice items derived from the official grammar rules.

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Exam map and method

Section	Items	Points
Non-finite verb forms	15 gaps	15
Tense and aspect	20 gaps	20
Modal items	15 gaps	15
Relative clauses	10 gaps	10
Theory and analysis	15 MC	15
Translation	10 sentences	25

THE 20-SECOND DECISION ROUTINE

1. Name the target. Is this tense/aspect, a modal meaning, a non-finite governor, a relative case, inversion or an article?
2. Read the full context. The same form can express different meanings.
3. Build the verb phrase. Finite auxiliary first, then non-finite forms in the correct order.
4. Check structure. Commas, relative case, do-support, if-clause sequence and article choice.
5. Read once for meaning. A grammatically possible sentence can still be the wrong interpretation.

Highest-yield fact
Translation is 25% of the exam. Practise complete sentences, not isolated rules.

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Non-finite verb forms

Pattern	Meaning / rule	Example
preposition + -ing	to, by, without, instead of, about...	look forward to hearing
make/let/have + object	bare infinitive	made me rewrite it
would rather / had better	bare infinitive	would rather stay
stop doing	end the activity	stop smoking
stop to do	pause in order to act	stop to smoke
remember doing	past memory	remember meeting her
remember to do	future obligation	remember to call
try doing	test a method	try restarting it
try to do	make an effort	try to open it
need doing	active form, passive meaning	needs repairing
used to do	discontinued past habit	used to study late
be used to doing	be accustomed to	is used to studying

Governor lists
Gerund: admit, avoid, deny, enjoy, imagine, mind, risk, suggest. To-infinitive: decide, expect, hope, manage, offer, promise, refuse, seem, tend.

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Tense, aspect and conditionals

Form	Core use	Strong cue
simple present	habit, truth, timetable, future sub-clause	often; schedule; when/if
present progressive	ongoing, temporary, arranged future	now; until; booked
present perfect	unspecified past, current result, up to now	ever; yet; since/for
present perfect progressive	duration/activity, visible result	for/since; why so wet?
simple past	definite finished past	yesterday; last year
past progressive	background/interruption	was doing when...
past perfect	earlier than a past point	had done before...
will	spontaneous decision / factual prediction	I will do it now
going to	intention / evidence-based prediction	plan; dark clouds
future perfect	completed before a future point	by Friday

Conditional	If-clause	Main clause
probable	present	will + infinitive
improbable	past	would + infinitive
impossible past	past perfect	would have + participle

Never forget
Future time clauses use a present form: When you arrive, I will call. Third conditional never uses would have in the if-clause.

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Modals and relative clauses

Modal	High-yield meaning	Contrast
must	deduction / speaker authority	have to = external obligation
cannot have	past impossibility	may not = possibly not
had better	urgent advice + consequence	should = weaker advice
need not have done	did it; it was unnecessary	did not need to = action unclear
was able to	specific fulfilled past ability	could = general past ability
be to	order / formal plan / fate	not automatically should
be supposed to	rumour / expected obligation	meaning depends on context
must not	prohibition	do not have to = no obligation

RELATIVE CHECK

- Defining: no commas; that possible; zero only for an object gap.
- Non-defining: commas; no that; no zero pronoun.
- Fronted preposition: to whom / about which, never to that.
- Partitive: ten people, few of whom; five books, all of which.
- Connective which: can refer to the whole preceding clause.
- What: means that which and contains its own antecedent.

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Word order, determiners, translation

Topic	Rule	Example
mid position	before lexical verb; after be; after first auxiliary	often goes; is often; will probably go
degree/manner	after all auxiliaries	has been completely revised
end order	manner - place - time	worked quietly at home yesterday
inversion	negative/restrictive fronting	Never have I...; Only then did I...
simple-verb inversion	do/does/did + base form	Only yesterday did I meet...
few / a few	hardly any / some count nouns	few people / a few people
little / a little	hardly any / some uncountable	little time / a little time
institution	zero = function; the = place	go to court / go to the court
body part	possessive normally; the after affected-object phrase	his hand / hit him in the hand

FINAL TRANSLATION CHECK

1. Underline the target and the time reference.
2. Choose tense/aspect and modal meaning before translating vocabulary.
3. Check non-finite governor, conditional sequence and reported-speech backshift.
4. Check relative case, commas, articles, possessives and inversion.
5. Use a complete natural sentence and a real apostrophe.

Exam morning
Redo saved mistakes, complete one short translation set, then stop adding new rules.